dynasty which, with the beneficent gaze of your imperial greatness, without doubt will return to its former favourable state.'[28]

So it was that Nesselrode recommended the Tsar to send what he described as a trade and diplomatic mission to Afghanistan: 'No matter how far removed the above countries [Afghanistan and India] are from us,' he wrote, 'and how limited our knowledge of them, it is undeniable that any broadening of trade relations is profitable.'[29] The only problem was that Mirza Hussein Ali showed no signs of recovering from his illness. So, after many meetings, it was finally decided that Vitkevitch should set off ahead of the Ambassador, who was too unwell to attempt the journey south without at least one month of rest.

On 14 May 1837, Vitkevitch was given a set of written instructions, which talked of opening trade relations with Dost Mohammad. According to one Russian source, he was also given a set of secret oral instructions about buying Dost Mohammad's full support by offering him financial aid of two million roubles to be used against Ranjit Singh's Sikhs, and the promise of military supplies with which the Afghans could reconquer their winter capital of Peshawar, lost since Shah Shuja's failed expedition of 1834.[30] In addition, he was to try to bring Dost Mohammad's Barakzai half-brothers in Kandahar into the new alliance too and urge them to unify and act as one with their brother in Kabul. It was, he was told, of the utmost importance 'to achieve peace between the Afghan rulers . . . and to make them understand the immense advantages of a close and amicable relationship between them, advantages for them personally and for their domains, which could thus be much better defended against external enemies as well as against internal disturbances'. Throughout, Vitkevitch was to take detailed notes and on his return write a full report on 'the current state of Afghanistan, its trade, finances and army, and the attitude of the Afghan rulers towards the British'.[31]

Vitkevitch was to travel through the Caucasus, accompanied by Captain Ivan Blaramberg who had just been appointed to the Russian delegation in Teheran as Simonitch's adjutant.[32] After resting at Tiflis, they were to disguise themselves and, with the greatest secrecy and discretion, make their way to Teheran. 'Once in Teheran,' Vitkevitch was told, 'you shall report to Count Simonitch, and place yourself under his orders. It will be up to him to decide whether to send you on to Afghanistan or to cancel your mission if he considers it incompatible with the political situation in Persia